party. Over time it became a vigorously political actor, as well as a fractious one. A number of extremist factions emerged from the party, including the Sami ul-Haq faction [JUI-S] and the Fazl-ur Rehman faction [JUI-F], both of which sported ties to the Taliban movement that developed in Afghanistan during the 1990s.[54]

After Zia seized the levers of power in 1977 he set about enshrining Sunni Islam as the law of the land. Two years later, regime change came to Iran. The 1979 revolution that swept a Shia theocracy into power was a watershed event, which inspired and invigorated Shia Muslims worldwide. The ensuing mobilization of Shia identity 'galvanized the Shi'a into a distinct political group in Pakistan's politics.' This triggered an initial power struggle between the Pakistani state and its Shia community, followed by a broader and bloodier competition between Pakistan's Sunni and Shia Muslims.[55] The emboldened Shia community rejected Zia's Islamization program, which was based on Sunni interpretations of Islam. When Zia attempted to implement the Zakat Ordinance, Pakistan's Shia community objected and mobilized against it. Zakat is the practice of alms-giving and is obligatory for all Muslims able to do so, but Shias believe a ruler cannot impose it and so the ordinance violated their religious beliefs. The Shia community protested vigorously and Zia retreated, granting them an exemption. Pakistan's Sunni Islamists erupted in anger, with some arguing that the Shia, by refusing to submit to Sunni law, were 'outside the pale of Islam.'[56] Sunni and Shia organizations formed to protect their communities' interests and were soon engaged in sectarian attacks on one another. By 1988 the violence entered a new dimension with a series of sectarian assassinations and expanded during the 1990s, claiming almost 600 lives by 1997.[57]

The central government poured money into bolstering existing Sunni madaris [the plural of madrasa—religious school or seminary] and founding new ones. Much of this funding was diverted to the NWFP and Balochistan, provinces bordering Shia Iran. It also supported Sunni militant groups as part of its strategy to solve the 'Shia problem.'[58] External support further fueled the violence. Saudi Arabia, which considers itself the heart of the Sunni Muslim world, sought to check Iranian influence, leading the two countries to fund a sectarian proxy war in Pakistan. Iraq contributed as well and along with Saudi Arabia provided additional financing to Sunni